On the security front, two major Rohingya exoduses (first in 1978–79 and the second in 1992) have dominated border proceedings between these two countries, when the Rohingya people crossed into Bangladesh in large numbers, reportedly due to military oppression in Rakhine State (see Table 1 for details). There were also a few skirmishes in which lives were lost;[2] some involved unilateral violation of borders by the NaSaKa, Myanmar's former border forces.[3][4] A series of incidents took place in 2008 when Myanmar hired Daewoo to carry out gas exploration in the Bay of Bengal in areas where Bangladesh ordered naval deployments, believing them to be in its own waters. The crisis deepened when Myanmar also initiated troop movements in Rakhine and Chin States opposite the Bangladesh border and which, in turn, triggered war-like deployments of the Bangladesh Army and Border Guards. However, Daewoo withdrew immediately after, without further escalation of tension (Alexander's Gas & Oil Connections 2008; Mizzima 2008).

In recent times relations between the two countries have improved. Apart from diplomatic visits at the top levels, businesspeople have been frequenting both countries relatively easily, thanks to better access due to new air routes offered by several airlines.[5] Although the two countries have not signed a major security pact since the 1980 agreement on border cooperation, a landmark verdict was nonetheless obtained through the International Tribunal on the Law of the Seas in March 2012 concerning delineation of the common maritime boundary in the Bay of Bengal — one that was accepted by both governments (Sen 2014).

THREAT PERCEPTIONS AT THE BORDER

Security — or insecurity for that matter — is subjective, and is usually rooted in the perception of threat (Ahmed 2010, p. 68). This remains true even when the threat is misperceived and proved at a later stage to be without basis. As has been the case with incidents at the Myanmar–Bangladesh border in the past, measures taken on one side — out of a perfect or imperfect understanding of threats — have direct effects on perceptions of the problem on the other side, and affect countermeasures.

The classical or neo-classical realist school may encourage modern nation-states to view their neighbours as the closest possible threat and to develop defence plans accordingly (Lobell 2012, pp. 42–43), but such